

A Vendor/Developer Perspective

TECH SUPPORT

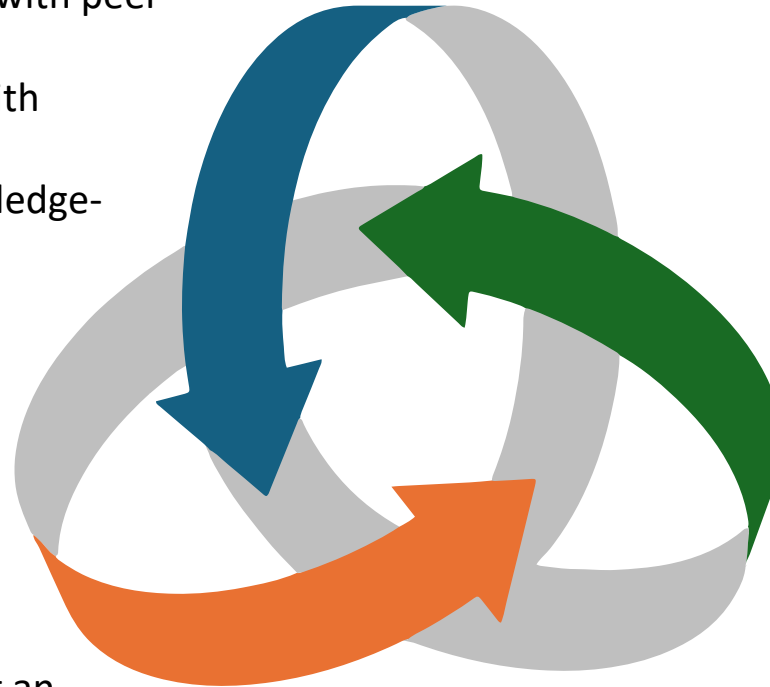
- Augment user-to-developer with peer-to-peer
- Augment product support with application support
- Augment training with knowledge-sharing

USER GROUP

- Offer such a forum for developers that do not offer their own
- Offer an open, autonomous substitute for closed developer-led, developer-moderated groups

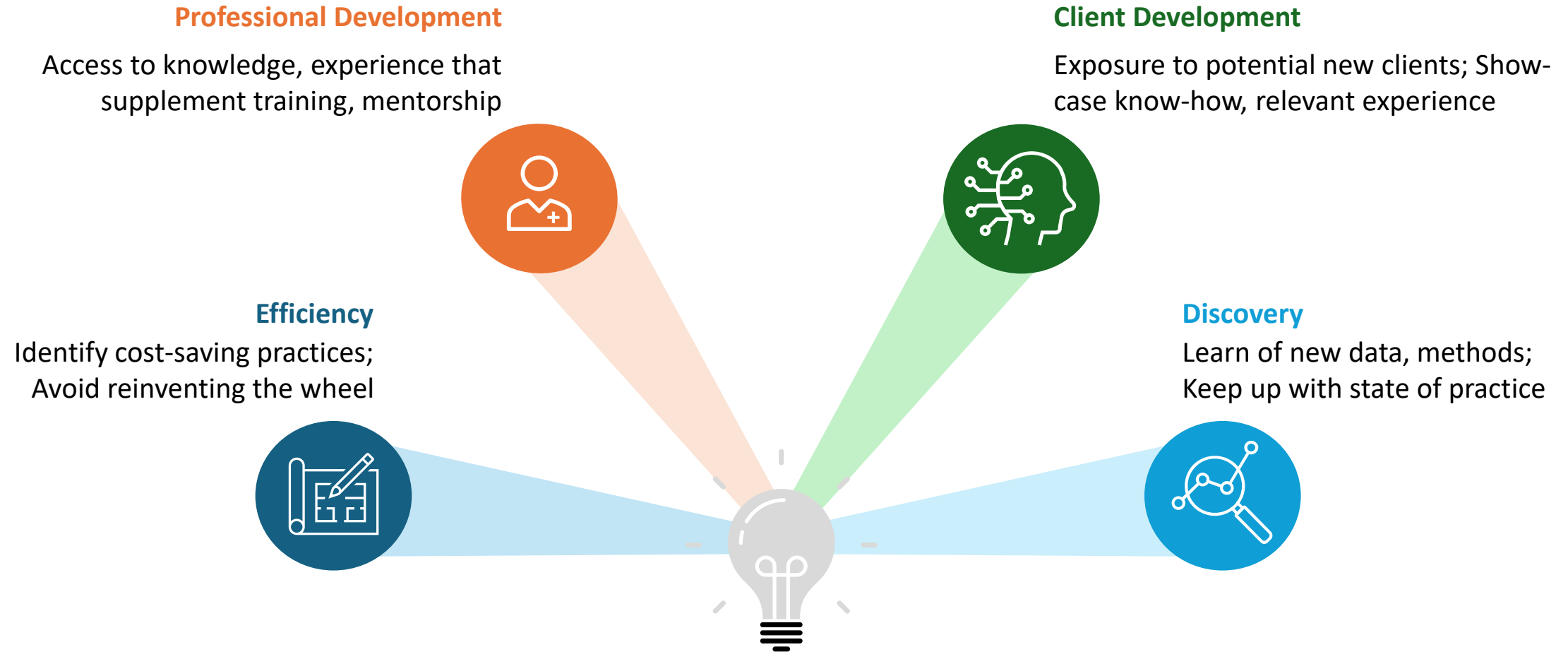
CONFERENCES

- Fills gap in national conferences having an emphasis on modeling
- Fills gap in engagement for those short on travel budget/authorization



Common Modes
of User-Developer
Interaction

A Consultant Perspective



Value Proposition of a Community of Practice for Consultants

SWOT Analysis

Strengths

- Community addresses a “real, widely-felt problem”
- “Early champions”
- “Adoption by influential users” or organizations

Weaknesses

- No checks or balances in unmoderated self-government
- Fairness and egalitarianism are not organic things
- Open-source solutions thrive on a large, active “maintainer team,” but this practice community is (relatively) small

Opportunities

- Build/grow your brand, exposure
- Increase knowledge, professional growth
- Find efficiencies
- Discover new data and methods
- Access to support not covered by tech support, training

Threats

- Sharing = giving away the store
- Volunteerism is not billable
- Open-source solutions hinge on a “responsive, welcoming community”
- Sustainable without funding (see TMIP as example)?
- Would-be contributors overstretched

What Might a Useful Community Entail?

A “reddit-style” online forum

- Exchange of ideas aimed at avoiding reinventing the wheel
- Share data sets useful for testing/proving developer or academic solutions
- Share academic publications relevant to topics raised in forum

An Email Listserv

- TMIP Listserv a model that sees relatively frequent usage and robust exchange of ideas
- Direct-to-inbox alternative to forum for those that prefer to consume information this way

An AI trained on this forum, listserv would be able to:

- Summarize community’s needs and thus service an FHWA objective (community feedback)
- Identify to vendors what kinds of problems the public and academics are trying to solve with their tools and what software features may best serve those needs
- Identify to academics and TRB committees research needs and other fodder for research needs statements